POTO ME PIPI

Episode 2

Written by Allan George

THE HUNT FOR THE NOTE NINJA

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SERIES LOGLINE:
In the town of Tāpito, Pipi the brave ngeru and Poto the clever kurī, inspired by comic detective Matua Mātai, solve whimsical mysteries while teaching tamariki empathy, problem-solving, and te ao Māori values.

EPISODIC LOGLINE:
After school, Pipi and Poto hunt for the “note ninja” leaving anonymous compliments all over Tāpito, only to discover it’s shy Hina the hedgehog, and the real challenge is helping her share her kindness out loud.

1 **EXT. STREET - AFTERNOON** 1

The school bus pulls away in a cloud of dust. Pipi and Poto step onto the kerb outside Koro Tama's house, still talking. They both look a bit *down*.

POTO
Today's maths was really hard.

PIPI
At least you're not as bad at drawing as me.

POTO
Your circles are pretty round.

Poto's eyes catch something. A corner of paper sticking out of the MAILBOX at the gate.

POTO
Wait.

Poto rushes over and reaches in. He pulls out a handwritten NOTE sitting on top of a PARCEL. He studies it, confused.

PIPI
What is it?

Poto flips the note around and hands it to her. It reads in careful letters: ***"Pipi. You're awesome at drawing!"***

PIPI
(reading, softly)
"Pipi. You're awesome at drawing." *(beat, glancing at Poto)* Who...would write that?

POTO
I don't know.

Pipi or Poto glance up and down the street. There's a brief gust of wind. Things feel eerie for a moment.

Pipi reaches into the mailbox and pulls out the parcel. It's addressed to: KORO TAMA.

PIPI
(determined, tucking the note away)
Let's find out who did this.

2 **INT. KORO TAMA'S HOUSE - LOUNGE - CONTINUOUS** 2

Pipi hands the parcel to KORO TAMA, he begins unwrapping it.

PIPI
Koro, we found a mystery!

KORO TAMA
(distracted, pulling out a RED BEANIE)
Mm-hm?

He puts on his beanie and turns to face them.

KORO TAMA (CONT'D)
(strikes a pose)
How do I look?

PIPI
Koro, focus! We've got a real-life mystery on our hands!

Poto sets his bag down on a chair. A small NOTE flutters to the floor. He picks it up: ***"Poto, you're so good at maths!"*** Poto reacts with a small smile to the compliment. A brief moment of pride.

POTO
Pipi look.

PIPI
Ah! Another one!

Poto picks up and holds the note out for Pipi to see. They simultaneously lean forward, heads nearly bumping together, to examine the note closer.

This entire time, Koro Tama has been looking at himself in the mirror in the background, studying himself, striking different poses. He adjusts the beanie slightly, frowning a little at his reflection. Not convinced he looks good in it.

KORO TAMA
(quietly, to himself)
Is it sitting a little high?

He tugs it down. He still looks uncertain.

PIPI
Ready?

Poto nods. They do a quick, secret handshake, exchange a determined look, and the MUSIC builds to...

MONTAGE: DETECTIVE MODE ACTIVATED

- *They put their hats on.*
- *They put their oversized coats on.*
- *Pipi and Poto look through their magnifying glasses.*
- *They stand proudly next to each other, detective mode is on!*

3 **EXT. KORO'S GARDEN - PĀTAKA KAI - AFTERNOON** 3

NOTE: *'Detective Mode' has a different aesthetic.*

The scenes and shot sizes, composition reflect classic (film noir) detective cinema. What has their attention has a blue glow like nature to it.

A cork board displays toy animal photos, colourful fingerprint sketches, a hand-drawn map with an X, a list of clues written in wobbly letters and newspaper clippings.

Pipi adjusts her magnifying glass and squints at the board.

PIPI
I think it was a masked hero.

Pipi dramatically gestures towards a sketch of a masked hero.

INSERT:

Pipi's imagination is like a child's drawing, a MASKED PERSON, a low-budget superhero walks into shot. They wear a tea towel tied round their shoulders as a cape and a swimming goggles over their eyes..

The masked person pulls a crumpled piece of paper from their pocket. They stick it in Koro Tama's mailbox.

PIPI (O.C.)
(detective voice)
Someone who leaves notes and vanishes into the night!

They slink back out of shot with absurd, exaggerated care and caution.

CUT BACK TO:

Close on Poto's skeptical reaction to Pipi's dramatic theory.

POTO
(detective voice)
No, wait. It's Tāwhirimātea. The wind suddenly picks up.

INSERT:

A gust of wind sweeps through an open window lifting notes from a desk and scattering them across the room before tumbling out into the street below. As they fall, the papers flutter and dance spinning through the air like leaves.

POTO (O.C.)
(detective voice)
He blew someone's notes out a window. They got stuck all around town.

EXT. STREET - CONTINUOUS

The notes caught in the breeze tumbled end over end down the footpath, clinging to fences mailboxes doors and even cars.

CUT BACK TO:

Pipi isn't convinced.

POTO (CONT'D)
Actually... what about the mailman!

PIPI
We have to find out who's leaving these notes around before our parents pick us up!

POTO
I forgot!

We cut to Pipi holding 20 pens.

PIPI
It has to be a masked hero. Someone fast. With lots of pens.

Pipi grabs a pencil and sketches a quick, simple picture of someone. She pins it to the cork board with a thumbtack. She fusses over it a second, feeling self-conscious.

POTO
That's Ariki. You're way better at drawing than you think.

Pipi's confidence visibly grows she smiles then straightens up.

PIPI
(detective voice)
The builder.

The kids position themselves back-to-back, arms crossed, holding up their magnifying glasses, mimicking Mātua Mātai's famous stance, which is also in the poster.

POTO AND PIPI
(adjusting his detective hat)
Let's crack this case wide open!

PIPI
(excited)
Mātua Mātai would be proud of us! He'd say we're real detectives.

We push in on that faded Mātua Mātai poster pinned to the wall. Mātua Mātai comes alive and flicks his eyebrows at us.

4 **EXT. TĀPITO STREETS - AFTERNOON** 4

Pipi and Poto walk along the footpath, stopping a CAT who's sipping a green smoothie as they pass.

PIPI
(detective voice)
Have you seen Ariki?

The Cat says nothing, takes a big sip from the straw and just walks off.

They spot WHAEA LUCIA tending to her front garden. Pipi approaches.

PIPI (CONT'D)
Whaea, did you get a note?

WHAEA LUCIA
(smiling, holding up a scrap of paper)
I did, actually. It made my morning, whoever wrote it.

WHAEA LUCIA (CONT'D)
It's gonna go straight to the fridge.

POTO
What about your drawings, Pipi? Her fridge's going to run out of space!

Everything darkens around Pipi's face. The music deepens, we hear thunder and lightening. A dagger to the heart.

PIPI
(reverb)
The fridge's going to run out of space...

Back to normal. Poto scans the street. Across the road, SOMEONE smiles as they show their NOTE to a FRIEND.

POTO (CONT'D)
They're everywhere!

Across the road, a TEENAGER finds a note on their backpack, reads it, and grins, then shows it to their friend.

Close on one stuck to a BIKE HANDLE as it rides by, one taped on a LIBRARY BOOK someone is carrying as they walk by, another taped to SOMEONE'S hat as they walk by too.

PIPI
We're terrible at this…

POTO
Every great detective has to start somewhere, right?

Pipi glances away for a moment. When she looks back at Poto, there's a NOTE stuck to the his detective jacket.

PIPI
You got a note!

POTO
You have one too! On your hat!

Poto looks around. Who could have done that? He looks back at Pipi who now has a note on her detective hat.

Pipi and Poto peel the note off and read it at the same time: ***"You're an awesome detective"***

PIPI AND POTO
(reading)
"You're an awesome detective."

PIPI
Maybe if we don't even blink, we'll spot them next time!

They examine each note closely. Same handwriting. Same little doodle in the corner of each one.

PIPI (CONT'D)
It has to be Ariki. He's the one stealing my fridge space!

POTO
Maybe but if it is, We need proof.

PIPI
He's the fastest person I know and he has lots of pens and paper in his van.

They begin walking off down the road. Eyes WIDE open.

POTO
I don't think it's Ariki. He's not really into stationery.

PIPI
(detective voice)
Let's catch him in the act. We're not stopping until we find him.

We cut wider. Another mysterious note flutters by unnoticed.

6 **EXT. TĀPITO DAIRY - LATER** 6

They spot ARIKI, a broad-shouldered tradie, leaning against his VAN with a small NOTEBOOK in his hand, jotting something down.

PIPI
There! Over there!

Poto pulls Pipi aside as she lunges to confront Ariki.

POTO
Wait! We need to catch him in the act.

Ariki finishes writing something then moves towards the dairy.

They hurry over, eyes wide.

PIPI (CONT'D)
Gotcha!

AUDIO: DETECTIVE STING.

ARIKI
(looking up, confused)
What?

POTO
You've been leaving notes!

ARIKI
(laughing, confused)
No, I haven't.

PIPI
You have! What’s that in your hand?

He holds up his notebook. It's full of measurements and sketches for jobs.

PIPI
Oh.

POTO
(apologetic)
We’ve been finding notes all over town, we’re trying to find out who it is.

ARIKI
Actually, I just found this on my steering wheel.

He shows them a NOTE: ***”Ariki, you're the best builder ever.”***

POTO
So you got one too.

ARIKI (CONT'D)
(softer, genuine)
Did you kids put that there?

PIPI
No...

Pipi and Poto walk away slowly, shoulders slumped. Pipi stops then looks at the note in Ariki’s hand as they walk away

PIPI
What if the notes stop and people who need them don't get them?

They sit down on a nearby bench, defeated.

A moment passes. We hear the birds and cars in the distance.

POTO
Remember that story about Mātua Mātai and the case of the midnight jandal?

INSERT:

A Mātua Mātai comic with the title **“Mātua Mātai #3 - The Case of the Midnight Jandal”** is lifted up into shot.

BACK TO:

PIPI
Yeah he did a stakeout and...

Pipi clicks.

PIPI AND POTO
He set up bait!

7 **EXT. KORO’S HOUSE - FRONT LAWN - AFTERNOON** 7

Pipi and Poto have sat Koro Tama in a chair on the front lawn in front of a full length mirror. He’s wearing his red beanie adjusting it.

KORO TAMA
I just don’t know. I think I look silly in this! AHHHH.

Pipi and Poto are watching from the bushes near the fence.

PIPI
(whispering)
If anyone’s going to draw attention, it’s Koro.

KORO TAMA (O.C.)
I look so silly!

LATER:

Koro Tama is now asleep snoring, beanie weirdly placed on his head.

Pipi and Poto are bored.

PIPI
How long do we have to wait? UGH!

Across the street, HINA (7), a small hedgehog wearing overalls wanders over. She glances around, checking no one is watching. She scribbles a note then continues over to Koro Tama.

They bust out of the bush!

POTO
Gotcha!

PIPI
Wait, Hina, those notes are from you?

AUDIO: DETECTIVE STING.

Hina attempts to avoid eye contact.

HINA
(shy, caught)
Oh. Um. Yes.

PIPI AND POTO
Yes! Case closed!

DETECTIVE MODE DEACTIVATED *

POTO
But why are you leaving notes all over the place?

Pipi edges in closer to Hina.

PIPI
Yeah why?

HINA
I saw Mr. Tahiroa at school, tugging at his new shirt. He looked so… sad. Sometimes it’s easier to write things down.

PIPI
Why don't you tell people?

Hina fidgets with her pens, crayons and paper, she continues to avoid eye contact, struggling to find her words.

HINA
(quietly)
I dunno. I just... can't. I'm just too shy.

Koro Tama snores loudly.

POTO
Hina, what you're doing... it's awesome!

Hina's face grows a small smile and she looks up at the two of them.

HINA
(unsure)
Really?

Another snore.

PIPI
We can help you!

POTO
Maybe we could say something together?

Hina takes a deep breath.

HINA
(nervous but hopeful)
Okay.

8 **INT. KORO TAMA'S HOUSE - LOUNGE - LATER** 8

Koro Tama sits in his armchair, the RED BEANIE still on his head, watching a programme. He touches the brim self-consciously.

Pipi and Poto enter, walking straight toward him with exaggerated confidence. Hina hangs back in the doorway, watching.

PIPI
Koro, we have something to say. Well Hina does.

KORO TAMA
(turning, amused)
Oh and what is that Moko?

A brief beat of hesitation.

HINA
Your beanie is... um... it's very...

She looks over at Pipi and Poto who give a thumbs up.

HINA
Um... I just... I think the beanie is cool, actually.

POTO
Really good.

PIPI
I love it!

Koro Tama smiles then moves over to the mirror, this time his reflection seems to please him.

KORO TAMA
Not bad then aye. Handsome guy. Feel free to admire what it is that you see before you.

HINA
(barely audible)
It suits you.

KORO TAMA
(genuinely pleased)
Well, thank you, Hina. That's very kind.

Outside, the late afternoon sun slants across the street.

Somewhere in Tāpito, someone is reading a note, we hear them in the distance.

RANDOM PERSON
A little note... for me? Look, someone’s spreading good vibes!

THE END.